Roasting the squash concentrates and develops its flavor beautifully, and leaves you free to get on with making a hot rouille sauce, which gives this soup its vigor.

roasted squash soup

SERVES 6 **PREP** 30 MINS **COOK** 50 MINS **FREEZE** UP TO 3 MONTHS

1½–2lb (675–900g) winter squash, such as pumpkin, butternut, or acorn, cut into chunks
1lb (450g) ripe tomatoes, coarsely chopped
6 garlic cloves, unpeeled
1 sprig of rosemary
2 sprigs of thyme
1 red onion, cut into 8 wedges
4 tbsp extra virgin olive oil
1.2 quarts (1.2 liters) hot vegetable stock or chicken stock
salt and freshly ground black pepper
small pinch of saffron
1 garlic clove, chopped
1 red chile, seeded and coarsely chopped
1 egg yolk
1 tbsp red wine vinegar
½ cup sunflower oil
4 tbsp extra virgin olive oil
12 croûtes (see p39)
freshly grated Comté or Gruyère, to serve

1 Preheat the oven to 425˚F (220˚C). Put the first seven ingredients into a roasting pan and turn to coat in oil. Roast, turning occasionally, for 45 minutes or until everything is very tender. Discard the herb stems, and scrape the rest into a blender. Add the stock and process until smooth. You may need to do this in batches. Pour into a large pot and season with salt and freshly ground black pepper.

2 Meanwhile, make a rouille. Soak the saffron in 1 tbsp warm water. Pound the garlic, chile, and a pinch of salt to a paste in a mortar, then work in the egg yolk and vinegar. Mix the two oils, then drip them in, whisking constantly. When one-third of the oil has been incorporated, increase the flow to a slow trickle. Stir in the drained saffron, then adjust the seasonings.

3 To serve, reheat the soup, then ladle into bowls. Pass the croûtes, the rouille, and the grated cheese around separately, so everyone can smear the croûtes liberally with rouille, float them in the steaming soup, and then finish with a sprinkling of grated cheese.